

Phase 3 completes the teaching of the alphabet, and children move on to sounds represented by more than one letter, learning one representation for each of at least 42 of the 44 phonemes of English. Just one spelling is given for each phoneme as this equips children with the ability to spell unknown words with invented spellings, as they will have a way of writing each sound.

Children entering Phase 3 will know around 19 letters and be able to blend phonemes to read VC words and segment VC words to spell. While many children will be able to read and spell CVC words, they all should be able to blend and segment CVC words orally.

The purpose of this phase is to teach another 25 graphemes, most of them comprising of two letters (e.g. **oa**), so the children can represent each of about 42 phonemes by a grapheme (the additional phoneme /zh/ found in the word **vision** will be taught at Phase 5.5). Children can also continue to practise CVC blending and segmenting for reading, and spelling simple two-syllable words and captions. They will learn letter names during this phase, learn to read some more Common Exception Words and also begin to learn to spell some of these words.

The sounds traditionally taught for the letters **x** and **qu** (/ks/ and /kw/) are both two phonemes, but children do not need to be taught this at this stage, as it does not affect how the letters are used.

Teaching materials in this phase suggest an order for teaching letters and provide a selection of suitable words. They are for using in the activities, practising blending for reading and segmenting for spelling. Just like Phase 2, these are not lists to be worked through slavishly but to be selected from as needed for an activity. Furthermore, as in Phase 2, it must always be remembered that phonics is the step up to word recognition. Automatic reading of all words (decodable and CEWs) is the ultimate goal.

Letter Progression

Phase 3 – Phonics

j	v	w	x	y	z	zz	qu	ch
sh	th	ng	ai	ee	igh	oa	oi	oo
ow	ar	air	ear	er	ur	or	ure	